

exam to your professor and he fixes his grade book, but does nothing to correct the overall situation. You still fail the class and have to repeat it. That would not happen. There would be a course of action to take to say the failing grade was due to an error and now the error has been fixed. Let me pass. Right now, the government looks the other way at universal default errors and lets you fail.

According to a 2005 survey, the latest data available, 44% of credit card banks surveyed take part in universal default. This survey was of forty-five different banks. These forty-five banks issued 144 different credit cards. That's a lot of universal default going on. Check your card member agreement, the fine print, to see if your bank has this policy. If it says that it may use "default pricing based on information in your credit report," then indeed, be prepared for universal default.

Maxed Out

In the 2006 documentary film *Maxed Out*, director James Scurlock turned the cameras on the consumer lending industry. The people he interviewed, average everyday American citizens, were "just being preyed on [by lenders] and manipulated and squeezed so hard that they can't ever hope to recover. And that's not right." I agree that it is not right, but people need to know that there is hope and that they can recover. Scurlock stated that he made the movie about the debt epidemic in America because "debt is the one issue that affects all of us – rich or poor, black or white, gay or straight, liberal or conservative."

Scurlock and his crew made a lot of interesting discoveries. In the film, he talked with a consumer attorney who spends the bulk of his time taking on the credit reporting agencies over errors. In the depositions of credit bureau attorneys, he has been told, on record, that over 90% of all credit reports have errors on them. Again, this seems like an area where the federal government should step up and require a more diligent and accurate reporting, an overhaul, a clean up to the system. Alas, they don't. It is up to us to be the watchdog of our credit reports, as we have learned how they impact every dollar we spend.

Also shocking to the makers of the movie was that the consumer lending industry is exploiting the extremely poor, the naïve college students, and the people who have declared bankruptcy. We'll take them, the financial industry, to task for that in the next chapter.